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making inroads in other states, the other parties got unhappy. That's why they keep telling me to stay in UP where I have my own Government and I can be safe. But if I don't go out of UP how will my party increase its base? The Uttar Pradesh Government wrote to the Central Government on the basis of intelligence reports and asked for SPG (Special Protection Group) cover for me. The Centre in turn asked why does she need the cover? She is the chief minister and should stay in the state. Why do they forget that I am the national president of a party as well?

Q. So you are saying your enemies want to limit you to UP?

A. Yes, but they will soon themselves be limited to a few states. When I ask the Centre for security they say yes, there is a need but we can't give it as it's a rule that SPG can only be given to PMS, ex-PMS and their families.

Q. Have you asked for the SPG Act to be amended?

A. I am not a PM or an ex-PM or the child of an ex-PM. If they can make an amendment for an ex-PM's family, then why not for a Dalit's daughter? I am a hard-working girl.

Q. You talked about the danger from a Congress leader. Who is he?

A. There is one Atiq Ahmad who is

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FEELING BLUE: Sonia and Rahul



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"What blackmail is there in asking for SPG for my security? I am not asking for money or a house for myself."



being protected by a Congress leader in Delhi. I will reveal his name when the time is right. When there is a warrant against Ahmad and we want to arrest him, why are they hiding him?

Q. You are a popular Dalit leader. Why should anyone harm you?

A. It's to do with the way BSP is racing ahead. Obviously, when BSP rushes ahead, other parties will be hurt. First the Congress, then BJP.

Q. Should Narendra Modi be given SPG cover too? You do concede he is more in danger than you are.

A. That is for the Gujarat state

SPREADING WINGS: Mayawati covered all of the south last month intelligence and the Central Government to decide.

Q. In 2004, before the elections, Sonia Gandhi did come and ask you for seat adjustments.

A. Yes, they wanted a seat adjustment. That is correct. Sonia did come and ask for a national-level alliance but we were not ready. I said my people do not want it. She was very *samajhdaar* (understanding), she did not grumble. She understood.

Q. What is your relationship with the Congress?

A. I don't need anything from the Congress or BJP. My party fights alone. In 1996 with the Congress, it was they who needed us when we had an alliance. Our votes were transferred to them but their votes were not transferred to us. That is when we decided that if we don't gain anything out of this, then why should we go in for an